

Playing the Faith Card

Taslima Nasreen is being used as a political weapon by MIM in its battle against the Left parties to regain its lost votebank



She is an exiled feminist writer from Bangladesh, living on a visa granted every six months by the Government of India. And barely a week before its extension, the feisty 45-year-old Taslima Nasreen suffered the most barbaric attack on her so far. Picking up whatever they could lay their hands on, three legislators of the local Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (MIM) rained books, flowerpots and chairs to disrupt the release of *Chellu ku Chellu*, the Telugu version of her book *Shodh*, in Hyderabad.

After three of the five MIM MLAs—Mohammed Moazzam Khan, Mohammed Muqtada Khan Karwan and Syed Ahmed Pasha Quadri—stormed the venue and indulged in vandalism, Muqtada tried to justify his party's shameful act by saying they could have done much worse. Even the party's floor leader in the Assembly Akbaruddin Owaisi showed no signs of remorse. "Whatever we did was right

IN ATTACK MODE: MIM MLAs target Nasreen at a press conference and we will repeat this act if that woman visits Hyderabad again. I am ready to face any consequences, including arrest," says Owaisi.

In a complaint made to the police, the MIM has accused Nasreen of hurting the sentiments of the Muslim community with her writings and speeches against Islam. Even the seemingly moderate, lone party MP Assaduddin Owaisi has said that he feels proud of his legislators. He further adds that she has "misused the asylum status given to her by the Government of India, unlike the Dalai Lama who has been staying in the country since 1950". "When the Bangladesh government has shunted her out of the country, then why is the Indian Government protecting her?", asks Sultan Salahuddin Owaisi, MIM president.

Though the attackers are roaming free,



charged with minor misdemeanours, the writer has been booked by the police under Section 153 of IPC.

Describing the assault as "horrifying" and "shocking", academics and writers have joined leaders of political parties and civil libertarians to condemn MIM for its act and to voice their apprehensions about the growing religious intolerance. "I believe in the principles of democracy and freedom of expression. The minorities attacked me but I still enjoy the support of the majority," said a shaken Nasreen.

"Such incidents are not acceptable in a civilised society," observed the newly-elected Vice-President Hamid Ansari. Even some sections of the emerging Muslim middle-class in Hyderabad, while disagreeing with Nasreen's views, have condemned MIM's ways, and have distanced themselves from the party's act.

Denying the charges that the ruling Congress is maintaining a soft stance towards its electoral ally MIM, Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy has termed it as a barbaric act. But his efforts have failed to get the police to act sternly on the issue.

Nevertheless, the local party could not have asked for more at a time when it is trying hard to rebuild its strength by playing the pro-Islamic card. MIM has whipped up emotions by pointing out that it is the communists who are supporting the controversial writer by giving her asylum in West Bengal. The Bangladeshi author is being used as a political weapon in MIM's battle against the Left parties to regain its lost supporters. The party is justifying its act by saying that had they not acted in such a manner against Nasreen, the next person invited to the city would have been "the blasphemous Salman Rushdie".

As for Nasreen, whatever be the fatwas issued against her and whether or not she is able to visit the city again, the attack has only strengthened her resolve instead of what the attackers had hoped for—silencing her.

by Amarnath K. Menon

"Whatever we did was right. I am ready to face any consequences."

AKBARUDDIN OWAISI, MIM LEADER